VERBAL

Reading Comprehension

Inference, Title & Tone

Assignment 5

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DIRECTIONS for the question: *Read the passage and answer the question based on it.*

Question No. : 1

Don Berwick believes that the subtleties of high-performance medical practice can be identified and learned. But the lessons are hidden because no one knows who the high performers really are. Only if we know the results from all can we identify the positive deviants and learn from them. If we are genuinely curious about how the best achieve their results then the ideas will spread.

Yet you have to wonder whether it is possible to replicate people like Warwick, with their intense drive and constant experimenting. In the few years since the Cystic Fibrosis Foundation began bringing together centers willing to share their data, certain patterns have begun to emerge. All the centers appear to have made significant progress. Yet if you look at the rates of improvement in different quartiles, it's the centers in the top quartile that are improving fastest.

Once we acknowledge that, no matter how much we improve our average, the bell curve isn't going away, we're left with all sorts of questions. Will being in the bottom half be used against doctors? Will we be expected to tell our patients how we score? Will patients leave us? Will those at the bottom be paid less than those at the top? The answer to all these questions is likely yes. Recently, for example, there has been a rapid shift toward "paying for quality." Across the country, insurers now hold back 10 percent or more of payments to physicians until specific quality goals are met. Not surprisingly, this makes doctors anxious.

I do not have to consider these matters for very long before I start thinking about where I would stand on a bell curve for the operations I do. The hardest question for anyone who takes responsibility for what he or she does is, what if I turn out to be average? If we took all the surgeons at my level of experience, compared our results, and discovered that I am one of the worst, the answer would be easy: I'd turn in my scalpel. But what if I were a B- ? I could tell myself, 'Someone's got to be average. If the bell curve is a fact, then so is the reality that most doctors are going to be average. There is no shame in being one of them, right?'

Except, of course, there is. What is troubling is not just being average but settling for it. Everyone knows that averageness is, for most of us, our fate. And in certain matters – looks, money, tennis – we would do well to accept this. But in your surgeon, your child's pediatrician, your police department, your local high school? When the stakes are our lives and the lives of our children, we want no one to settle for average.

Excerpted from 'Better' by Atul Gawande.

What could be the means adopted in order to test out Don Berwick's hypothesis mentioned in para 1?

A) Making it compulsory for doctors of all Cystic Fibrosis centers to take part in a Continuing Education Program to stay abreast of the latest research
B) Have the medical teams at Cystic Fibrosis centers more involved with their patients, by arranging for Focus Group Discussions with patient families.
C) Arrange for annual awards which honor the best performing Cystic Fibrosis centers so as to reward achievement and spur on all the centers.
D) Cystic Fibrosis Centers to publish on a www.cff.org their individual results, adjusted for the severity of disease in their populations.

Question No. : 2

What inference can be drawn about the Cystic Fibrosis centers in the top 25 percentile?

A) These centers have the most skillful and experienced doctors.
B) They have a capacity to learn and change and to do so faster than everyone else.
C) The infrastructure ratings of at these centers are also in the top 25 percentile.
D) These are centers where the team understands the importance of data and decisions that can be taken based on the same.

Question No. : 3

All of the following are valid objections to the concept of grading doctors, except..

A) Grades never seem to measure the right things. B) Grades don't take into account circumstances beyond our control.
C) Grades can be misused D) Doctor's salaries are going to be paid according to their grades

Question No. : 4

All of the following are implied as the reasons for the better results shown by the Cystic Fibrosis center run by Dr Warwick, except..

A) Aggressiveness B) Diligence C) Ingenuity D) Knowledge and technical skill

DIRECTIONS for the question: *Read the passage and answer the question based on it.*

Question No. : 5

How quickly things change in the technology business! A decade ago, IBM was the awesome and undisputed king of the computer trade, universally feared and respected. A decade ago, two little companies called Intel and Microsoft were mere blips on the radar screen of the industry, upstart start-ups that had signed on to make the chips and software for IBM's new line of personal computers. Though their products soon became industry standards, the two companies remained protected children of the market leader.

What happened since is a startling reversal of fortune. IBM is being ravaged by the worst crisis in the company's 79 year history. It is undergoing its fifth restructuring in the past seven years as well as seemingly endless rounds of job cuts and firings that have eliminated 100,000 jobs since 1985. Last week IBM announced to its shell-shocked investors that it lost $4.97 billion last year - the biggest loss in American corporate history.

And just when IBM is losing ground in one market after another, Intel and Microsoft have emerged as the computer industry's most fearsome pair of competitors. The numbers on Wall Street tell a stunning story. Ten years ago, the market value of the stock of Intel and Microsoft combined amounted to about a tenth of IBM's. Last week, with IBM's stock at an 11-year low Microsoft's value surpassed its old mentor's for the first time ever ($26.76 billion to $26.48 billion) and Intel ($24.3 billion) is not far behind. While IBM is posting losses, Intel's profits jumped 30% and Microsoft's rose 44%.

Both Intel, the world's largest supplier of computer chips, and Microsoft, the world's largest supplier of computer software, have assumed the role long played by Big Blue as the industry's pacesetter. What is taking place is a generational shift unprecedented in the information age - one recalls a transition in the US auto industry 70 years ago, when Alfred Sloan's upstart General Motors surpassed Ford Motor as America's No. 1 car maker. The transition also reflects the decline of computer manufacturers such as IBM, Wang and Unisys and the rise of companies like Microsoft, Intel and AT&T that create the chips and software to make the computers work. "Just like Dr. Frankenstein, IBM created these two monster competitors, "says Richard Shaffer publisher of the Computer Letter "Now even IBM is in danger of being trampled by the creations it unleashed."

Although Intel and Microsoft still have close relationships with Big Blue, there is little love lost between IBM and its potent progeny. IBM had an ugly falling-out with former partner Microsoft over the future of personal-computer software. Microsoft developed the now famous disk operating system for IBM-PC – called DOS – and later created the operating software for the next generation of IBM personal computers, the Personal System/2. When PS/2 and is operating system, OS/2, failed to catch on, a feud erupted over how the two companies would upgrade the system. Although they publicly patched things up, the partnership was tattered. IBM developed its own version of OS/2, which has so far failed to capture the industry's imagination. Microsoft's competing version, dubbed New Technology, or NT, will debut in a few months and will incorporate Microsoft's highly successful Windows program, which lets users juggle several programs at once. Windows NT, however, will offer more new features, such as the ability to link many computers together in a network and to safeguard them against unauthorized use.

IBM and Intel have also been parting company. After relying almost exclusively on the Santa Clara, California Company for the silicon chips that serve as computer brains, IBM has moved to reduce its dependence on Intel by turning to competing vendors. In Europe, IBM last year began selling a low-cost line of PC's called Ambra, which runs on chips made by Intel rival Advanced Micro Devices. IBM also demonstrated a sample PC using a chip made by another Intel enemy, Cyrix. And this October IBM said it would begin selling the company's own chips to outsiders in direct competition with Intel.

IBM clearly fells threatened. And the wounded giant still poses the biggest threat to any further dominance by Intel and Microsoft. Last year, it teamed up with both companies most bitter rivals – Apple Computers and Motorola – to develop advanced software and microprocessors for a new generation of desktop computers. In selecting Apple and Motorola, IBM bypassed its longtime partners. Just as Microsoft's standard operating system runs only on computers built around Intel's computer chips, Apple's software runs only on Motorola's chips. Although IBM has pledged that the new system will eventually run on a variety of machines, it will initially run only computer programs written for Apple's Macintosh or IBM's OS/2. Its competitive juice now flowing, IBM last week announced that it and Apple Computer will deliver the operating system in 1994 – a year ahead of schedule.

Note: The Article above was written in 1993.

One possible conclusion from the passage is that

A) Share prices are not a good indicator of a company's performance. B) Firing workers restores a company's health.
C) All companies ultimately regret being a Dr. Frankenstein to some other company.
D) Consumers gain as a result of competition among producers.

Question No. : 6

Which of the following statements is true?

A) IBM plans to introduce a new system that will run on a variety of machines.
B) IBM's new generation desk top computers will run only on Motorola's chips.
C) IBM is working out a joint strategy with Apple to force Motorola to supply chips at a lower price.
D) IBM is going to sell its own chips to Apple and Motorola.

DIRECTIONS for the question: *Read the passage and answer the question based on it.*

Question No. : 7

Often, the hardest step in speculative paleo-anthropology lies in overcoming assumptions. So let us back up and begin by asking a very basic question: *Why is it that a human female generally has to compete with other women to get a mate?*

Nature's story is nearly always about two sexes with markedly different agendas. For a male, each time he prevents one of his rivals from copulating with a female, that is one more womb which might be induced to carry forward his genetic heritage. The same is not normally true for a female, looking at males. Once engaged in gestation, her reproductive success is unaffected by copulations taking place nearby. When there is an abundance of food, one female gets little or no direct benefit by denying any other female a chance to reproduce, or to be inseminated by the same male.

A leading hypothesis holds that humans became paragons of adaptability by emphasizing general, species-wide behavioral and mental neoteny. Further, our offspring are born *altricial*, replacing reflex instinct with lessons drawn from experience and the accumulated wisdom of the tribe, channeled by only the most general of innate predispositions. This process takes a long time, during which our children are helpless as no others in the history of life on Earth.

The presumption goes that human mothers need long-term, dependable partnership to help them carry big-brained, dependent children across the hazardous, exhausting stretch from embryo to maturity. And while some human societies have used brother-sister alliances to fill this need, or communal role-sharing, the majority have left mothers primarily dependent on continued loyalty and aid from the fathers of their children.

Now by definition, monogamous species have approximately equal numbers of successful male and female breeders, so one might expect both to behave similarly, competing the same amount with others of the same sex. But this is *not* the case, because most "monogamous" males are not *purely* monogamous in every sense of the word. Generally, these males do not give their mates so much absolute *fidelity* as *devotion*... meaning they will do anything and everything to serve and protect the nest and their offspring. But, given an opportunity to engage in outside sex *without* risk or harm, they will often take advantage.

For example, the females of many bird species force prospective mates to engage in lengthy, exhausting courtship "dances" and other displays, before becoming sexually receptive. For years this was thought to involve *species identification* -- preventing hybrid insemination by a related species. But plumage, scent, and a thousand other simpler markers are available to accomplish the same end. Now it is thought that mating dances serve more directly pragmatic role, by culling out philanderers. Few already-mated males can afford the time and energy -- exhausting themselves in an effort at wooing -- if they already have a mate and nest elsewhere. To male birds, monogamy may not mean *absolute* fidelity, but it does mean having priorities.

Excerpted from 'Neoteny and Two-Way Sexual Selection in Human Evolution' by David Brin

In the third paragraph, the italicized word *altricial* is closest in meaning to?

A) Selfish B) Retention of childlike characteristics in mature members of a species C) Nearly unformed
D) Juvenilization of appearance

Question No. : 8

Based on additional information given below, answer the question that follows.

During each annual mating season, females congregate onshore. If food is plentiful and the beach roomy enough, there is small cause for struggle between females, so most behaviorists used to be drawn to the noisy, extravagant displays of competing males. Known as a "beach master," each bull elephant seal outweighs any female many times over. By threat, bluster, and frequent bloody fights, he drives off all male interlopers to secure a local monopoly over insemination. Females acquiesce to this situation. Indeed, should the bull be away at the far end of his territory, and a rogue male attempt mating on the sly, females will often squall for the beach master to come drive the invader out.

Why do female elephant seals prefer to share one male rather than get individual attention?

A) Female elephant seals, unlike humans, have no sentimentality.
B) Since females rear their kids alone, the choice of a mate is determined solely by factors which might reflect the quality of his genes.
C) The survival of the fittest ensures that the non-alpha males are all killed off by the dominant bull.
D) The dominant bull punishes any deviant females who attempt mating with any other rogue male on the sly.

Question No. : 9

In her book, **The Woman That Never Evolved**, Sarah Hrdy (1981) shows that harem systems differ dramatically. Some, such as the gray langur monkey, can be much more stressful than that of elephant seals. _____ Also, while a mother langur doesn't need provisioning by a mated male, she does require the security of her troop. For these reasons, the bull langur has no single rutting season. To maximize reproduction, he must "police" his harem year-round. And, since his prime period averages only a few years, it is in his Darwinian interest to see that all local females serve his reproductive needs. One bloody consequence is that a new bull, on taking over a langur troop, often kills unweaned infants so that their mothers will resume ovulating sooner.

Which of the following best fills the gap?

A) By mating with as many males as possible mothers are able to successfully protect their young.
B) Biology, it is sometimes thought, has worked against women.
C) Langur mothers don't cycle through well-timed mating seasons, but re-enter estrus when their latest child either weans or dies.
D) Langur mothers are continually making trade-offs between quality and quantity and weighing the best possible actions for both her and her infant.

Question No. : 10

Based on your understanding of the passage, which of the following could be the reason for most birds being monogamous?

A) Like human children, bird chicks are fairly defenceless at birth and take a long time before they can take to flight.
B) Some of the offspring raised by a monogamous pair come from the female mating with an extra-pair male partner.
C) Serial monogamy resembles polygyny in its reproductive consequences because some males are able to utilize more than one female's reproductive lifespan through repeated pairings.
D) Chicks must grow fast to achieve flight before the seasons change. This, plus a high metabolism, means few avian young survive on the labor of one parent alone.

QNo:- 1 ,Correct Answer:- *D*

Explanation:-
Option 4.
In para 1, it is stated that the subtleties of high-performance medical practice can be identified and learned.
However as they are hidden at present and hence only if we know the results from all can we identify the positive deviants and learn from them.
Option 4 is correct because if CF Centers publish on a www.cff.org their individual results, adjusted for the severity of disease in their population, one can learn from them.
None of the other options will give any data which will be used to learn.

QNo:- 2 ,Correct Answer:- *B*

Explanation:-
Option 2.
Refer to the line, Yet if you look at the rates of improvement in different quartiles, it's the centers in the top quartile that are improving fastest.'

QNo:- 3 ,Correct Answer:- *D*

Explanation:-
Option 4.
Option 1 is justified because if we have a scale which measures short term recovery of a patient and grade a doctor on that - then we may be measuring the wrong thing.
Option 2 is also a valid objection - where the lack of infrastructure in a hospital can lead to worse outcomes. This is beyond the control of a doctor.
Option 3 is also true. For example all patients may only want to go to a doctor who is getting high grades - in which case overall patient care will suffer.
Option 4 is not a valid objecion because there is no harm in doctors getting salaries based on performance. In a lot of cases, this is already happening.

QNo:- 4 ,Correct Answer:- *D*

Explanation:-
Option 4.
Refer to the line - 'Yet you have to wonder whether it is possible to replicate people like Warwick, with their intense drive and constant experimenting.' This justifies options 1 and 3.
The drive can also be used for justifying the 'diligence' of option 2.
Option 4 is not implied - as the theme of the talk is more about the unique processes that lead to excellence, rather than the standardised knowledge / skill that most doctors have through their training and education.

QNo:- 5 ,Correct Answer:- *C*

Explanation:-
The passage states that each company feels threatened by its own creations.

QNo:- 6 ,Correct Answer:- *A*

Explanation:-
Refer to last paragraph - IBM has pledged that the new system will eventually run on a variety of machines. . .. .

QNo:- 7 ,Correct Answer:- *C*

Explanation:-
The passage states that the human offspring replaces reflex instinct with lessons drawn from experience and the accumulated wisdom of the tribe, channeled by only the most general of innate predispositions.
This means that the offspring is immature or not fully developed.
Hence, nearly unformed is the best answer.

QNo:- 8 ,Correct Answer:- *B*

Explanation:-
Option 2.
The paragraph stated states that the females submit to the dominance of one male bull elephant seal.
In the passage it is said that a female chooses a mate keeping two things in mind: how much support would she get and what genes does she think will pass onto the conceived unborn.
In case of the bull seal elephant, one male drives off all male interlopers to secure a local monopoly over insemination.
If support was what the females got from the males then many females would not accept one mating partner.
This means the females rear their kids alone.
Then the other factor, which is genes, would become a predominant factor.
Hence option 2 is the best option.

1 - sentimentality is a typical human trait - and option 1 is only stating the obvious.

3 - there are battles, but the non-alpha males do not get killed

4 - The battles mentioned are more with males than females. This behavior may actually result in putting off the females.

QNo:- 9 ,Correct Answer:- *C*

Explanation:-
Option 3.
As we are talking of a harem maintianed by the male laungur monkey, females getting an opportunity to mate with more than one is not possible and neither can she make any trade offs.
Hence option 1 and 4 are incorrect.

The blank has to be filled by some information about the langur as the next sentence starts with the word also.
So option 2 is ruled out.

If the females do not have a fixed mating season then the next sentence that the male laungur has no single rutting season makes sense.

QNo:- 10 ,Correct Answer:- *D*

Explanation:-

Option 4.

The passage states that these males do not give their mates so much absolute fidelity as devotion... meaning they will do anything and everything to serve and protect the nest and their offspring.

Hence, if the chick needs to grow fast so as to survive the season changes and if the metabolism of the chick is high, the food intake will be enormous which cannot be sustained by one parent alone.

Hence, option 4 is the best answer.

1 - raises the issue of why chick rearing is burdensome, but does not touch on the monogamy part.

2 - The extra marital affairs of the birds do not weigh so much on the child rearing

3 - Sounds abstruse enough but its connection to child rearing is dubious.